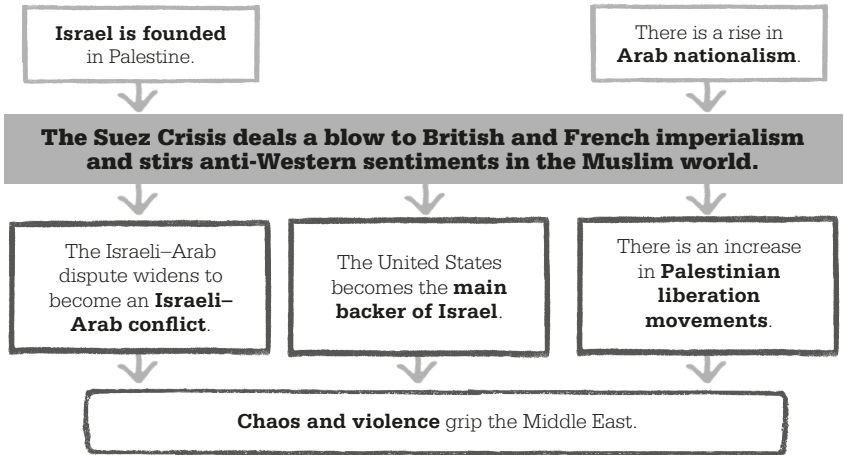




a United Nations resolution imposing a ceasefire, and British and French troops had to conduct a humiliating withdrawal.

Splitting the land

The strong anti-Western sentiment in the Middle East dates back hundreds of years, fueled by the West's increased involvement in the region. Colonialism in the 1800s and the division of the Ottoman Empire after World War I were bitter humiliations for peoples who felt their religion, Islam, was the highest form of divine revelation. In 1948, the partition of Palestine to form Israel split the land into two states, one Arab and one Jewish, and was rejected vehemently by Israeli Arabs and enraged the other Arab nations. The regular armies of the Arab states—including Iraq, Lebanon, Syria, Transjordan, and Egypt—attacked Israel in the first Arab–Israeli War in May and June 1948. The conflict ended in defeat for the Arabs and disaster for the Palestinians: more than half of the country's Arabs were uprooted as refugees, and they lost any possibility of a state of their own.

Ambitious plans

Egypt continued its stance of belligerence toward Israel by closing the Suez Canal to Israeli shipping. When Nasser ousted the regime of King Farouk in 1952 and sent him into exile, he imported arms from the

Soviet Union to build his arsenal for future confrontations with Israel. Britain had agreed to withdraw its troops from the Suez area by June 1956, but as the last troops left Egypt, Nasser relied on funds from Britain and the US to fund ambitious plans to develop Egypt. This included the Aswan Dam project on the Nile. Nasser was angered when Britain and the United States withdrew their offer of loans to help him pay for the dam. The US and Britain backed out because of Nasser's association with the Soviets and his unceasing diatribes against the West. Nasser felt insulted and immediately nationalized the Suez Canal. The move was popular in Egypt, as the canal was a source of Arab pride.

Nasser was a secular modernizer who advocated the separation of religion from political life, believing it the hallmark of Arab modernity, but this was not universally welcomed. The Muslim Brotherhood, founded in Egypt in 1928, argued for Islam to have a central role in government. After repeated calls for the application of Sharia law—a legal system based on Islam—and an assassination attempt against Nasser, the organization was finally banned in 1954.

In 1967, Arab countries suffered a crushing defeat at the hands of Israel in the Six Day War, in which Israel took the Sinai from Egypt, the Golan Heights from Syria, and the West Bank and East Jerusalem »